

Historic breakthrough: On a day that will be etched in the annals of Jammu and Kashmir cricket, the side (**facing page**) toppled two-time champion Bengal by six wickets in Kalyani to storm into its first-ever Ranji Trophy final. RITURAJ KONWAR

plays for India,” said Ajay.

The J&K players’ joy knew no bounds as they acknowledged the sporting gesture of the local fans, who had supported Bengal to the hilt before applauding the visitors for their fine show, and then shook a leg inside the victorious dressing room.

Y.B. Sarangi

Match abhi zinda hai

One of the golden rules in Indian sports journalism is to never underestimate the average intelligence of an Indian cricket fan. The Diary found this out firsthand in February 2024 at a Test match in Ranchi when it sat among supporters for half an hour and came back humbled. Another moment of reckoning happened during the same contest when the Diary, at a press conference, mistook Dhruv Jurel for Jitesh Sharma and was corrected by none other than the player himself.

What unfolded at the Ekana Cricket Stadium in Lucknow during the Karnataka-Uttarakhand Ranji Trophy semifinal this February falls into the same category. The final day of the fixture was largely academic, and the Karnataka players, having gained a massive first-innings lead, wanted to shake hands and confirm their place in the final against Jammu and Kashmir.

The Diary too was fidgety and wanted the match to end by 2 p.m. Why 2 p.m.? There was no rational basis for it. But when the umpires called for tea at 2.10 p.m. and players started congratulating each other, the Diary was ecstatic.

It walked down the stairs with a spring in its step, and just as it crossed the giant electronic scoreboard en route to the players’ pavilion, it saw the person manning



Renewed pursuit: Skipper Devdutt Padikkal led Karnataka’s charge with a first innings double hundred. R.V. MOORTHY

it just waking up from his afternoon slumber. The Diary, in its hardly passable Hindi, said: “*Match khatm... aap so rahe the* (The match is over... were you sleeping)?”

However, 10 minutes later, to the Diary’s bewilderment, it was made known that play had not been called off because Karnataka, having taken six Uttarakhand wickets in the second innings, still had a genuine chance of an outright victory, and the umpires were duty-bound to allow play until such a possibility was completely negated. The Diary trudged back with a sheepish smile, and it was not long before it came face to face with the electronic scoreboard operator.

“*Sir mujhe pata tha. Match abhi zinda hai* (I knew the match was still alive),” he said, much to my embarrassment.

It felt like the Diary had not learnt its lesson from two years ago. So, it is worth repeating: never underestimate the average intelligence of an Indian cricket fan. Never.

N. Sudarshan



Brief scores Semifinal 1

Karnataka 736 (Padikkal 232, Rahul 141, Smaran 135, Rawat 4-154) and 323 (Smaran 127, Rahul 86 not out, Mishra 4-69) drew with Uttarakhand 233 (Raichandani 55, Patil 3-40, Vyshak 3-45) and 260 for 6 (Sudha 66, Negi 57 out, Gopal 3-83)

— Karnataka qualified on the basis of first-innings lead

Semifinal 2

Jammu & Kashmir 302 (Samad 82, Shami 8-90) and 126 for 4 (Vanshaj 43, Samad 30 not out, Akash Deep 3-46) beat Bengal 328 (Gharami 146, Nabi 5-87) and 99 (Shahbaz 24, Sunil 4-27, Nabi 4-36) by six wickets



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